A TRAIL OF VIOLENCE

Recent attacks and extortion threats allegedly linked to the Bishnoi gang that have Bollywood on edge



LAWRENCE BISHNOI



ANMOL BISHNOI

- **APR. 2024:** Two men on a motorcycle open fire outside Salman Khan's home in Bandra (West). The attack is traced to the Lawrence Bishnoi gang
- **OCT. 2024:** Ex-minister and NCP leader Baba Siddique is shot dead. Anmol, Lawrence's brother, is named as the prime accused. Siddique was close to Salman, though his family alleges a builder-politician nexus in the murder
- **SEPT. 2025:** Suspected Bishnoi gang associates open fire at actor Disha Patani's family home in Bareilly, Uttar Pradesh
- **FEB. 2026:** Alleged Bishnoi gang members fire shots outside filmmaker Rohit Shetty's home in Juhu. Later in June, he gets a Rs 20 crore extortion audio, believed to be Lawrence associate Shubham Lonkar's voice
- **FEB. 2026:** A man identifying himself as gangster Harry Boxer, a Bishnoi aide who is later detained in the US, allegedly threatens actor Ranveer Singh's manager, and demands Rs 20 crore

target and strike fear in Bollywood and Mumbai to extort money," says a veteran Mumbai Police investigator. Another official says Shroff was an "easy target" because he did not have personal security.

Hrithik was working as a rider for an app-based service, and Rehan and Phool are said to have arrived in Mumbai around September 20. Rehan and Phool were known for "violent conduct" and had criminal records, says a police official. The three men have been booked for attempt to murder, conspiracy and under relevant sections of the Arms Act. Jatin is said to have acted as the conduit between the hitmen and Pandit.

The investigation has also uncovered an alleged weapons supply chain. Kunal, 21, who was released from Sonipat jail in July, was introduced to Pandit through an acquaintance. About a fortnight before the shooting, Kunal and Sumit, 19, collected a foreign-made pistol and 20 rounds of ammunition in Amritsar through a 'dead letter box' drop, without meeting the supplier. They were helped by Sameer, who accompanied the duo. Investigators are examining whether the consignment came through an arms pipeline operating across the Punjab border.

Two months earlier, Kunal had befriended 23-year-old Radha, a factory worker in Sonipat, and persuaded her to carry a pistol. On October 15, he dropped Radha and her friend Babita, also 23, at New Delhi railway station. The women travelled to Mumbai and checked into a lodge in Dadar. A minor reportedly collected a bag from them on October 17. The women returned to Delhi on the day of the shooting aboard the Haridwar Express and were arrested at New Delhi railway station. Pandit is alleged to have spent money "in a scale of lakhs" on the operation.

The pistols were discarded and have yet to be recovered. National Investigation Agency officials suspect Sonipat is emerging as a recruitment ground for organised crime, given the number of people from the area allegedly involved in such operations.

UNDERWORLD 2.0?

The attack on Shroff is seen as part of the Bishnoi gang's expanding footprint in Mumbai, where the underworld once operated with relative impunity. A series of police 'encounters' in the 1990s and 2000s, coupled with the gentrification of criminal gangs and their shift to businesses, such as real estate, helped bring it under control.

Would the Mumbai Police seek custody of the Bishnoi brothers? Roushan says the process was "sub-judice" and that the police would "follow the legal route and the SOPs". A Union home ministry order bars investigating agencies from taking the Bishnoi brothers out of jail. While Lawrence has been in custody since 2015 and in Sabarmati Central Jail in Gujarat since August 2023, Anmol was deported from the US in 2025 and is lodged at Tihar jail in Delhi.

SHROFF MAY NOT HAVE BEEN THE GANG'S FIRST CHOICE. THE SHOOTERS REPORTEDLY CONDUCTED RECONNAISSANCE AT THE HOMES OF SALMAN KHAN, AMITABH BACHCHAN AND AAMIR KHAN, BUT WERE DAUNTED BY THEIR SECURITY

Former Mumbai Police assistant commissioner Avinash Dharmadhikari believes the gang faces a major hurdle: unlike the dons of yore, such as Dawood Ibrahim, Arun Gawli and Chhota Rajan, Bishnoi lacks a strong local base. "These people had local networks, something that Bishnoi does not have," he explains.

Mumbai's policing has changed considerably since the heyday of the old dons, with better intelligence-sharing, closer coordination between agencies and greater use of technology. Will these measures be enough to keep the underworld at bay? ■